

SERIES

Ethiopia

All the pieces in the series in a single document, in reading order. Updated 5 November 2026.

The war in Ethiopia, rarely reported: first the guide to find your bearings, then the in-depth pieces on the Pretoria peace agreement and on the war in Amhara. The fourth piece shows how the war risks merging with Sudan's. At the end comes the country profile, with the peoples, the history and the actors, for readers who want to go deeper.

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1/5 · ANALYSIS · 6 OCTOBER 2026

Ethiopia, the war no one is covering: a guide to understanding it

IN BRIEF

- Since 23 September 2026 Ethiopia has been at war again. On one side is the federal government of Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed; on the other, an alliance of seven armed groups formed on 20 September, led by the forces of Tigray and the Amhara Fano militias, which is calling for the government's fall.
- On 3 and 4 October the federal army retook Mekelle, the capital of Tigray, without a fight: the Tigrayan forces withdrew, saying they would regroup elsewhere.
- This is not only an Ethiopian war. The government accuses Eritrea, Sudan and Egypt of backing the rebels; all three deny it. On 4 October their leaders, together with Somalia's, signed a joint declaration that contests Ethiopia's ambitions on the Red Sea and the Nile point by point.
- Caught in the middle are millions of civilians: about 750,000 people were still displaced in Tigray before the fighting resumed.

On 3 October, in Mekelle, residents watched the Tigrayan fighters leave the city. A few hours later came first the militiamen of a Tigrayan formation allied with the government, then the federal army (Al Jazeera). There was no battle. For the third time in six years the capital of Tigray, in northern Ethiopia, changed hands; for days communications were cut and the people who live there feared looting (AP). In Italy the news went almost unnoticed. Yet in 2020-2022 Ethiopia fought one of the deadliest wars of this century, and today that war is starting again, wider than before. This guide tries to explain who is fighting, why, and what is at stake beyond Ethiopia's borders too.

THE COUNTRY IN THREE MINUTES

Ethiopia has about 135 million inhabitants, according to UN estimates for 2025 (UNFPA): it is the second most populous country in Africa after Nigeria, with more than twice the population of Italy. Tigray alone, where the war began, has about 7 million. The country hosts the headquarters of the African Union and has no access to the sea: it lost it in 1993, when Eritrea became independent and took the whole coastline with it, including the port of Assab. Since the 1995 Constitution it has been a federation of regions drawn largely along ethnic lines: Tigray,

Amhara, Oromia, Afar, Somali and others. It is a country of about 80 ethnic groups, and its political fault lines often follow identity lines.

Abiy Ahmed has governed since 2018. In 2019 he received the Nobel Peace Prize for ending the conflict with Eritrea. A year later he was at war in Tigray, with Eritrea as an ally. On 5 October 2026 he was sworn in for a second five-year term.

> ACRONYMS AT A GLANCE
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> - **TPLF**: Tigray People's Liberation Front: Tigray's party and armed forces, which led Ethiopia until 2018
> - **ENDF**: Ethiopian National Defense Force, the federal army
> - **TPF**: Tigray Peace Force, a Tigrayan militia allied with the government
> - **Fano (AFNM)**: nationalist militias from the Amhara region
> - **OLA**: Oromo Liberation Army, a guerrilla force in Oromia
> - **ANURF / Ugugumo**: armed group from the Afar region, crossed by the road to Djibouti
> - **ONLF**: Ogaden National Liberation Front, in the Somali region
> - **BPLM, GPDM**: armed movements from the Benishangul-Gumuz region, on the border with Sudan
> - **RSF**: Rapid Support Forces, the militia fighting the army in Sudan
> - **GERD**: Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam, on the Blue Nile
> - **ACLED**: independent group that collects data on armed conflicts

HOW WE GOT HERE

- **2018.** The Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF), which had dominated the federal government for 27 years, loses power after years of protests. Abiy becomes prime minister.
- **2020-2022.** War between the federal government and the TPLF. Eritrean troops and Amhara militias fight alongside the army. Estimates of the dead range from fewer than 100,000 (Ethiopian officials) to about 600,000 (the African Union mediator Olusegun Obasanjo). On 2 November 2022 the Pretoria agreement, signed in South Africa, ends the war: we covered it here.
- **2023.** The government tries to disarm Amhara's regional forces. The Fano militias, which had fought alongside the army, rise up (the war in Amhara).

- **2025.** The TPLF's registration as a party is revoked. Tigray is excluded from the national elections of June 2026 (The Conversation).
- **April 2026.** The TPLF removes the interim administration set up under the Pretoria agreement and reinstates the former regional president, Debretsion Gebremichael (Crisis Group).
- **Summer 2026.** Federal drone strikes on Tigray. The TPLF denounces a blockade of funds, fuel and access to banks; recruitment and mobilisation resume in the region.
- **20 September.** Seven armed groups announce an alliance to overthrow the government (Africanews).
- **22-23 September.** Between 15 and 17 drone strikes hit Alamata, in southern Tigray, including schools and a hospital, according to the monitoring group ACLED. The next day the TPLF takes the airports of Mekelle, Axum and Shire and attacks towards Amhara and Afar. It calls it a "defensive war".
- **28 September - 4 October.** Federal counter-offensive: Alamata, then Mekelle's airport, then the city.

WHO IS FIGHTING

The government side

- **ENDF**: the Ethiopian National Defense Force, the federal army. It has an air force and drones.
- **Tigray Peace Force (TPF)**: a Tigrayan militia born from a split in Tigray's forces, now allied with the government. It was the first to enter Mekelle.
- Regional police forces and local militias.

The opposition alliance (the "Ethiopian People's Forces Alliance for Survival", 20 September 2026). Stated goal: to remove Abiy's government and open a transition.

- **TPLF**: the Tigray People's Liberation Front, with its armed forces. The strongest member.
- **Fano (AFNM)**: Amhara nationalist militias, unified in the Amhara Fano National Movement. Their leader, Zemene Kassie, chairs the alliance.
- **OLA**: the Oromo Liberation Army, waging a guerrilla war since 2018 in Oromia, the most populous region.
- **The Afar front**: an armed group from Afar, the region crossed by the road and railway to Djibouti. Sources name it differently (ANURF, or Ugugumo, the historical name of the Afar insurgency).
- **ONLF**: the Ogaden National Liberation Front, in the Somali region. A faction abroad has joined; the leaders inside Ethiopia deny being part of it.

- **BPLM and GPDM**: two movements from the Benishangul-Gumuz region, on the border with Sudan.

Two caveats for reading this list. First: on paper there are seven members, but according to ACLED, as of 26 September only three of them were actually fighting: the TPLF, the Fano and the Afar group Ugugumo (Al Jazeera). The second is a paradox: the Fano now fighting alongside the TPLF are the same ones who in 2020-2022 fought against it alongside the federal army. And they remain divided on a decisive question: both Tigrayans and Amhara claim western Tigray, which the Amhara call Wolkait. The alliance unites groups that share an enemy, not a project.

WHY THEY ARE FIGHTING

Each side tells the story of this war differently, and the versions must be kept apart.

For the **federal government**, the TPLF violated the Pretoria agreement: it did not complete disarmament, overthrew the interim administration and attacked first on 23 September, with the help of foreign countries.

For the **TPLF**, it is Addis Ababa that hollowed out the agreement: Tigray was not reintegrated into federal institutions, the party was struck off, the region was excluded from the vote and strangled economically, and the drones struck before the offensive.

On some points independent sources agree. The question of the disputed territories, western and southern Tigray, was never resolved, and hundreds of thousands of displaced people have been unable to return home. The political mechanisms set up after the war have broken down. And the other insurgencies, in Amhara and Oromia, stem from grievances of their own, which the conflict in Tigray did not create but has made easier to weld together.

WHAT IS AT STAKE BEYOND ETHIOPIA

The sea and Eritrea. For Abiy, access to the Red Sea is an existential question. In September 2025 he called the loss of the sea a historic mistake that "will be corrected", and the return of the Eritrean port of Assab "a matter of time" (The Reporter). In 2026 he repeated that Ethiopia does not intend to invade anyone, but will not stop asking for a port (Africanews); on 5 October, being sworn in for his second term, he said he would work to secure an outlet to the sea (Al Jazeera). Eritrea fears precisely an invasion, and accuses Ethiopia of waging war to reach the sea. On 29 September Ethiopia's army chief, Field Marshal Birhanu Jula, accused Eritrea, Sudan and Egypt of backing the armed groups, describing Eritrea as the go-between linking foreign powers and the rebels. The three countries rejected the accusations (Al Jazeera). On 1 October Ethiopia closed its embassy in Asmara and expelled ten Eritrean diplomats and one Egyptian;

Eritrea responded by severing diplomatic relations, Egypt by expelling an Ethiopian diplomat (Al Jazeera).

Sudan. The accusations mirror each other. Ethiopia accuses Sudanese forces of backing the TPLF and the other armed groups; the Sudanese army calls this "baseless" and in turn accuses Ethiopia of helping the Rapid Support Forces (RSF), which it has been fighting since 2023. Addis Ababa denies it.

The Nile. On 9 September 2025 Ethiopia inaugurated the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam (GERD) on the Blue Nile, the largest hydroelectric plant in Africa, with more than 5,000 megawatts. Egypt and Sudan, which depend on the river's waters downstream, see it as a threat and contest Addis Ababa's unilateral decisions. Negotiations between the three countries are stalled (Al Jazeera).

Somaliland. In January 2024 Ethiopia signed a memorandum with Somaliland, Somalia's breakaway region, to obtain access to the sea in exchange for possible recognition. Somalia considered it a violation of its sovereignty, and the memorandum was later shelved. On 26 December 2025 Israel became the first state to recognise Somaliland (The EastAfrican); Ethiopia has not done so and has taken no official position.

Djibouti. Almost all of Ethiopia's foreign trade, fuel included, passes through the port of Djibouti, along the road and railway that cross Afar. That is where part of the fighting has moved.

El Alamein. On 4 October, as the army was entering Mekelle, the leaders of Egypt, Sudan, Eritrea and Somalia met in Egypt. In their final declaration they reject any interference in the internal affairs of the region's states, any recognition of Somaliland, any unilateral measure on the Nile that harms Egypt and Sudan, and they claim the governance of the Red Sea for the coastal states alone (text of the declaration). They also set up a permanent consultation mechanism. They do not name Ethiopia, but every point concerns it. It is a snapshot of a regional bloc that has closed ranks against Addis Ababa.

LEGAL READING

1. The protection of civilians applies to everyone. In an internal armed conflict, Common Article 3 of the Geneva Conventions and Additional Protocol II, which Ethiopia ratified in 1994, apply. They prohibit attacks on civilians, protect schools and hospitals and prohibit pillage (Protocol II, Article 4). The obligations apply equally to the federal army, to the militias fighting alongside it and to the alliance's armed groups. The drone strikes on schools and a hospital in

Alamata, and any looting in Mekelle, must be measured by this standard, whoever is responsible.

2. Helping another country's rebels is prohibited. International law prohibits states from intervening in the internal affairs of another state by arming or funding rebel groups (the prohibition of the use of force, UN Charter, Article 2(4), and the principle of non-intervention, as clarified by the International Court of Justice in *Nicaragua v. United States* in 1986). If Ethiopia's accusations against Eritrea, Sudan and Egypt were proven, that would be a violation. But the same applies to Sudan's accusation that Ethiopia is backing the RSF. Today these are accusations, all denied, and they must be treated as accusations.

3. Asking for a port is lawful, taking one is not. A landlocked state may negotiate access and corridors. It may not threaten the use of force against the territorial integrity of another state (Article 2(4)). Assab is Eritrean territory. Abiy's words swing between historical claim and the promise not to use force: it is actions, not speeches, that decide which side of the line he falls on.

4. The Nile has two principles, not one. Customary law on international rivers holds together the equitable and reasonable use of waters, which Ethiopia invokes, and the obligation not to cause significant harm to other riparian states, which Egypt and Sudan invoke. On 23 March 2015 the three countries signed in Khartoum a Declaration of Principles that refers to both (principles III and IV) and commits them to settle disputes through negotiation (principle X). None of the three, however, has joined the 1997 UN Convention on international watercourses, which codifies the same rules: in the General Assembly vote Ethiopia and Egypt abstained, while Sudan voted in favour but has never ratified it. Neither principle prevails on its own: that is why negotiations are needed, and why their deadlock is a problem.

5. Somalia's territorial integrity. Recognising a breakaway region without the consent of the state it belongs to is considered, in prevailing practice, an interference with that state's territorial integrity. Ethiopia's 2024 memorandum and Israel's 2025 recognition must be measured against this principle.

THE SYMMETRY TEST

The four leaders at El Alamein invoked sovereignty, non-interference and international law. These are sound principles, and they apply to everyone, including them. In November 2021 a joint investigation by the UN Human Rights Office and the Ethiopian Human Rights Commission attributed to Eritrean troops unlawful killings, torture and sexual violence against civilians in Tigray (OHCHR). The Sudanese army led by Abdel Fattah al-Burhan, a signatory of

the declaration, is accused by a UN fact-finding mission of drone strikes on hospitals and markets, as we have documented. Invoking legality does not absolve those who invoke it.

The same goes for the Ethiopian government, which demands respect for its own sovereignty while claiming someone else's port and is accused of backing a militia in Sudan. And it goes for the alliance, which presents itself as the defence of Ethiopia's peoples. The same 2021 investigation documented serious violations by all the parties to the war: the federal army, Eritrean troops, Amhara forces and militias, Tigrayan forces. Those who fight together today have a past of reciprocal violence against the civilians of each other's communities.

EDITORIAL JUDGEMENT

This section expresses the site's position. It is separate from the facts set out above.

The war in Ethiopia has every feature that, elsewhere, would guarantee front pages: a country of enormous size, an international peace agreement collapsing, a concrete risk of war between states, a strategic trade route under threat. In Italy it arrives in a few lines. Part of the reason is complexity: too many acronyms, too many unfamiliar place names. But complexity is a reason to explain, not to stay silent.

There is also a lesson for the African Union and for every peace agreement. Pretoria stopped the fighting, but left open the questions that had caused it: the disputed territories, disarmament, Tigray's political representation. A peace that postpones the hard questions is a truce. When no one, neither the parties nor the guarantors, defended the agreement on its uncomfortable points, the war came back.

Finally, a caution that applies to us and to our readers. Around this war circulate readings that attribute everything to outside direction, to secret designs of distant powers. Foreign interests exist, and we document them when there is evidence. But explaining a war with a conspiracy is a way of not explaining it: it takes responsibility away from those who, in Ethiopia and in the region, make the decisions.

> **Update, 11 October 2026.** Since 7 October the clash with Eritrea has gone beyond accusations. Two witnesses interviewed by Reuters saw dozens of Eritrean soldiers in Adigrat, in Tigray, about 25 kilometres from the border (Al Jazeera); on 7–8 October Ethiopian drones struck Eritrean troops and ammunition in the area, according to the monitor ACLED and witnesses interviewed by AFP, and the Eritreans withdrew northwards (Africanews). On 10 October, according to residents, the federal army entered the town (Reuters). In a letter to the Security Council dated 8 October, Ethiopia accuses Eritrea of an “all-out invasion” up to 60 kilometres

> into Tigray and invokes the right of self-defence under Article 51 of the UN Charter (Al Jazeera). On 10 October Eritrea replied with a letter of its own: it calls the accusations a "declaration of war", asks the Council to condemn Ethiopia and adopt measures under Chapter VII, and accuses Addis Ababa of wanting to seize the port of Assab (Al Jazeera). Eritrea denies backing the TPLF; on the border crossing it has neither confirmed nor denied. Neither version has been independently verified, there are no casualty figures and, at the time of this update, the Security Council has not met.

WHAT TO WATCH

- Whether Mekelle holds, and the TPLF's strategy after the withdrawal: guerrilla war in the mountains or a new front.
- The fighting in Afar, along the road and railway to Djibouti.
- The accusations against Eritrea, Sudan and Egypt and any independent evidence; the risk of a direct clash between Ethiopia and Eritrea.
- The follow-up to the El Alamein declaration and Ethiopia's response.
- Reports from the UN Human Rights Office and OCHA on civilians and humanitarian access in Tigray, Amhara and Afar.

Sources: Al Jazeera (4/10/2026) · AP (3/10/2026) · AFP, The Africa Report (4/10/2026) · UNFPA, UN data 2025 · The Conversation (9/2026) · Crisis Group (25/9/2026) · Africanews (21/9/2026) · Al Jazeera, ACLED data (2/10/2026) · The Reporter (6/9/2025) · Africanews (4/3/2026) · Al Jazeera (5/10/2026) · Al Jazeera (29/9/2026) · Al Jazeera (1/10/2026) · Al Jazeera (9/9/2025) · The EastAfrican (27/12/2025) · El Alamein Declaration, text (4/10/2026) · Addis Standard (5/10/2026) · Declaration of Principles, Khartoum (23/3/2015) · OHCHR (3/11/2021) · Al Jazeera 7/10 · Africanews (ACLED/AFP) · Reuters 10/10 · Al Jazeera 9/10 · Al Jazeera 10/10

Verification note: the military facts come from news agencies (AFP, AP, Reuters) reported by Al Jazeera and The Africa Report, and from the monitoring group ACLED; with fighting under way, individual claims remain hard to verify independently. Accusations between states are reported together with the denials. The text of the El Alamein declaration is the one published by Eritrea's Ministry of Information. Looting in Mekelle is reported only as a fear expressed by residents, not as an established fact. Situation as of 5 October 2026.

Ethiopia: the peace signed in South Africa that no one defended

> *“We are in the situation of full-blown war now.” — Amanuel Assefa, TPLF vice-president, to Al Jazeera, 24 September 2026*

On 2 November 2022, in Pretoria, South Africa, the Ethiopian government and the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF) signed, under African Union mediation, an agreement for a permanent cessation of hostilities, known ever since as the “Pretoria agreement”. It ended one of the bloodiest wars of the century: two years of fighting in the north of the country, whose toll remains disputed. The African Union mediator, former Nigerian president Olusegun Obasanjo, spoke in January 2023 of about 600,000 dead; a Ghent University study estimated up to 500,000, while some Ethiopian officials put the figure below 100,000. In recent days that agreement has collapsed, and the people paying the price are once again the same.

FACTS

On 21 September 2026 seven armed groups, including the TPLF and forces active in Amhara and Afar, announced an alliance against the government of Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed. From 23 September an offensive was launched on several fronts; Tigrayan forces took control of three local airports, including Lalibela's. The federal army says it killed at least 272 TPLF fighters in Amhara: this is a partisan figure that no independent source has so far verified.

On 25 September the UN High Commissioner for Human Rights, Volker Türk, described a rising civilian toll. According to his office, on 22 September federal army airstrikes, some carried out with drones, hit five schools in Tigray, causing deaths and injuries; a mortar strike attributed to the army killed civilians in the town of Kobo, in Amhara (on 23 September according to the High Commissioner, on 24 September according to UN News: the sources differ on the date). The same office denounces the forced mass recruitment of civilians, children included, by the TPLF across Tigray, with reprisals against those who refuse and their families, and reports cases of arbitrary conscription by government forces as well.

The Secretary-General's spokesperson added that a drone hit a truck carrying food for displaced people in north-western Tigray, that phone and internet services are cut in the region, and that armed groups in Amhara have seized humanitarian vehicles. All this is happening where the IOM already counts some 750,000 internally displaced people left homeless by the previous war.

WHY THE AGREEMENT COLLAPSED

The November 2022 agreement rested on a few precise commitments: the disarmament of Tigrayan fighters, the restoration of humanitarian aid, the return of the displaced and, later, a solution for the territories disputed between Tigray and Amhara. According to the analysis published by the International Crisis Group on 25 September, none of these knots was ever truly untied: disarmament was not completed, the contested lands remained under Amhara control, preventing many Tigrayans from returning, and outside diplomatic pressure to reach a compromise was insufficient.

Meanwhile the Tigrayan camp split. Between April and May 2026 the TPLF ousted the interim administration created by the agreement and reinstated Debretsion Gebremichael at the head of the region; his predecessor, Getachew Reda, now an adviser to Abiy, accuses the TPLF of starting the hostilities.

Then there is Eritrea. In the 2020-22 war its troops fought alongside the Ethiopian army and were accused of some of the worst atrocities of that conflict. Asmara never signed the Pretoria agreement. Today the Ethiopian government accuses it of financing the new alliance, and Eritrea denies it; according to Crisis Group's assessment, it has quietly moved closer to its former enemy. These are a partisan accusation and an analysis, not established facts, and we report them as such.

LEGAL READING

The frame of reference is international humanitarian law governing non-international armed conflicts. Common Article 3 of the Geneva Conventions and Additional Protocol II, which Ethiopia has ratified, bind the federal army and every armed group in the same way: they prohibit attacks on civilians and on civilian objects such as schools, and require the passage of humanitarian aid to be allowed. The same Protocol prohibits recruiting children under fifteen; the Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child, also ratified by Ethiopia, raises to eighteen the limit for recruitment by armed groups.

The limit already pointed out on this site for the war in Amhara remains: Ethiopia has not ratified the Rome Statute, and the International Criminal Court can act only on a referral by the Security Council. Finally, the Pretoria agreement is not a treaty with a judge: it is a political commitment mediated by the African Union, whose survival depended on the will of the parties and on pressure from those who had promoted it.

IMPLICATIONS — SYMMETRY TEST

The symmetry test takes no effort here, because the source itself applies it: the UN High Commissioner's office attributes violations to the federal army (the strikes on schools, the mortar on Kobo, arbitrary conscription) and to the TPLF (the forced recruitment of children). Neither side can present itself as the only victim, and neither of the political causes at stake, the unity of the state or the autonomy of Tigray, makes it lawful to strike a school or enlist a child.

This site's judgment is that the collapse of Pretoria shows the same problem we see elsewhere: an agreement without guarantors and a rule without anyone to enforce it hold only as long as they suit everyone. When Ethiopia slipped out of international attention, no one watched over disarmament, returns and the contested borders. The price of that distraction is being paid again today by the civilians of the north, the same ones as four years ago.

Sources: Office of the UN High Commissioner for Human Rights, statement by Volker Türk (25/9/2026) · Spokesperson for the UN Secretary-General, briefing of 25/9/2026 · UN News (25/9/2026; 2/11/2022) · International Crisis Group (25/9/2026) · Al Jazeera (24/9/2026) · IOM, data on displaced people in Tigray · The National (16/1/2023)

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Ethiopia: the war the government still calls a “security problem”

> *“Throughout 2025, warring parties committed war crimes and other serious abuses.” — Human Rights Watch, World Report 2026*

THE FACTS

For more than two years, in Ethiopia's Amhara region, a national army and a militia born to defend its own community have fought each other with the same methods: summary executions, forced disappearances, attacks on hospitals. The government in Addis Ababa still calls it a public-order problem, managed first through a state of emergency and then through a military command answering directly to the prime minister. The conflict broke out in April 2023, when the announced dissolution of regional special forces was read by the ethnic-Amhara Fano militia as a forced disarmament.

Since then, fighting between the Ethiopian National Defence Force (ENDF) and the militia has never stopped. Human Rights Watch, in its World Report published on 4 February 2026, records that throughout 2025 warring parties continued committing war crimes and other serious abuses, including reports of drone strikes harming civilians in Amhara. The Global Centre for the Responsibility to Protect, updating its dossier on 6 May 2026, reports that since 2023 the UN and independent monitors have repeatedly documented extrajudicial killings, arbitrary detentions, forced displacement, destruction of property and attacks on healthcare. Hundreds of thousands of displaced people still live in formal and informal camps across Amhara and Tigray: in June 2025 some staged a three-day protest outside regional government offices demanding a safe return home — something no one can currently guarantee them.

LEGAL COMMENTARY

The most solid legal framing, given the documentation currently available, is international humanitarian law applicable to non-international armed conflicts: Common Article 3 to the Geneva Conventions prohibits any party to a conflict, state or non-state, from killing, torturing or cruelly treating those not taking part in hostilities. Ethiopia has signed but not ratified the Rome Statute: the International Criminal Court therefore has no automatic jurisdiction over the country, barring a UN Security Council referral — a structural limit that leaves individual accountability for these events almost entirely to Ethiopia's own domestic justice system. Some

advocacy organisations, including the Lemkin Institute, have described the situation in Amhara as an ongoing genocide: we report this as an advocacy position, not an established fact — no international judicial body or UN organ has so far qualified the conflict in those terms.

IMPLICATIONS — THE SYMMETRY TEST

The symmetry test applies directly here: the sources cited attribute violations to both actors on the ground, not to one alone. The Ethiopian government frames its operations as restoring law and order against an irregular militia — a position we report, even as human rights organisations dispute the methods used. Ethiopia appears among the 20 countries on the IRC's 2026 Emergency Watchlist, the annual list of contexts at greatest risk of humanitarian deterioration worldwide — yet it remains at the margins of international coverage, overshadowed by Gaza, Sudan and Ukraine. This site had not written about it at all, until today.

Sources: Human Rights Watch — World Report 2026, Ethiopia chapter · Global Centre for the Responsibility to Protect — Ethiopia · IRC — 2026 Emergency Watchlist

Sudan and Ethiopia, the war of the consulates: drones launched from Assosa and the risk of a war between states

IN BRIEF

- On Sunday 1 November Sudan filed complaints against Ethiopia with the UN Security Council and the African Union's Peace and Security Council. According to Khartoum, since February the Rapid Support Forces (RSF) have launched 187 attack drones from Ethiopian territory, in 70 attacks, with 484 civilian victims. These are Sudanese government figures that no one has verified.
- Between 2 and 4 November Ethiopia closed the Sudanese consulate in Assosa, near the border, and Sudan closed the Ethiopian consulate in Gedaref. Neither foreign ministry has officially explained why.
- Ethiopia denies the charge and accuses the Sudanese army of arming the Tigrayan fighters who resumed their war against Addis Ababa in September. Sudan denies that in turn.
- Both accusations have a basis documented by independent sources: a Reuters investigation into an RSF camp in Ethiopia, and reports of thousands of Tigrayan fighters fighting alongside the Sudanese army. Neither, however, is proven in its most serious part: drones launched with Ethiopia's consent, weapons supplied by Sudan to attack Ethiopia.
- International law forbids a state both to arm a neighbour's rebels and to let its own territory be used against that neighbour. The rule applies in both directions.

Assosa is a small town in western Ethiopia, a few dozen kilometres from the Sudanese border. Until a week ago it hosted a small Sudanese consulate. According to the Sudanese government, it also hosts something else: the runway from which, since February, drones have taken off to strike Sudanese power stations, fuel depots and cities. This week the consulate is gone. The accusations remain, and with them the risk that Sudan's civil war and Ethiopia's become a war between the two states.

THE FACTS

The power stations go dark (26–27 October). On 26 October drones attributed to the RSF hit six power stations in the states of Al-Jazira, White Nile, Sennar and Gedaref, leaving millions of

people without electricity. The next day it was the turn of the Al-Markhiyat transformer station on the outskirts of Omdurman, which supplies much of the capital (AFP, via Ahram Online). According to a UN count reported by the same agency, in the first three weeks of October drones killed more than 300 people in Sudan. That figure covers all drones, from all parties and wherever they take off.

The report and the complaint (1 November). On Sunday the Sovereignty Council, the army-led body that governs Sudan, published a report entitled "Launched from Ethiopia". It lists 70 attacks between 15 February and 27 October, with 187 "kamikaze" drones, the kind that crash into their target, and 82 munitions dropped by larger drones. It names three launch sites: Assosa airport, the Kurmuk and Geissan border area, and the Bahir Dar air base in Ethiopia's Amhara region. In October alone there would have been 28 attacks, with 97 drones (Arab News). As its main evidence, the report presents the onboard memory of a drone shot down on 20 September near Damazin, in Blue Nile state: the programmed route started from a point which, according to the Sudanese analysis, lies 1.7 kilometres inside Ethiopia. It also cites wreckage of Turkish-made Bayraktar Akinci drones said to have taken off from Bahir Dar (Middle East Monitor). There would be 484 civilian victims; the sources reporting on the document disagree on one point: whether they are all dead, or dead and wounded together (Euronews Arabic). The report also counts 176 soldiers killed. Among the incidents it cites, on 9 October in Wad al-Mahi, Blue Nile state, an attack on displaced families allegedly killed 30 civilians, 26 women and 4 children. Sudan asks Ethiopia to stop the attacks, to close the facilities used by the RSF and to pay compensation for the damage (same source).

The same day the foreign ministry filed the complaint with the UN and the African Union. The use of Ethiopian territory by the RSF, it writes, "is a hostile act" that places Ethiopia in violation of international law (AFP, via Kuwait Times). The report has not been published in full, and the flight data have not been examined by independent experts.

The consulates (2–4 November). According to a Sudanese official quoted by AFP, on 2 November Ethiopia declared the six staff of the Sudanese consulate in Assosa "persona non grata" and gave them 48 hours to leave (AFP, via Kahawatungu). A senior Ethiopian official confirmed the closure to Reuters without explaining the reason (Reuters, via TimesLIVE). On Wednesday 4 November Sudan responded with the same measure against the Ethiopian consulate in Gedaref. The two foreign ministries have not issued statements on the expulsions (Sudan Tribune). Amjad Farid, political adviser to the Sovereignty Council, said Sudan remains determined to defend its territory but "is making every possible effort to avoid an open war with Ethiopia" (Reuters, via Arab News).

Ethiopia's version. Addis Ababa denies supporting the RSF. Its last detailed official response dates from May, when Sudan made similar accusations. The Ethiopian foreign ministry called them "baseless" and turned the argument around: it is Sudan, it wrote, that violates Ethiopia's territorial integrity by hosting "mercenaries" of the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF), and Sudan has become a base for forces hostile to Ethiopia (Addis Media Network, Ethiopian state media). The Sudanese army, it added, gives those fighters "arms and financial support" (Al-Monitor). Since September, when the Tigrayan fighters resumed their offensive against the federal army, Ethiopia has also accused Egypt and Eritrea of supporting them (Al Jazeera, 28/9/2026). All three deny it.

HOW WE GOT HERE

The quarrel did not start this week. On 2 March Sudan reported for the first time drones entering from Ethiopian territory, without saying who was flying them (SUNA, via allAfrica). In May, after a drone attack on Khartoum airport, it recalled its ambassador from Addis Ababa, accusing Ethiopia and the United Arab Emirates (Fides).

The RSF camp. On 10 February Reuters published an investigation, based on fifteen sources and on satellite imagery, into a training camp for the RSF in Ethiopia's Benishangul-Gumuz region, the same region as Assosa. The images showed hundreds of tents; a note by the Ethiopian security services, seen by the agency, spoke of 4,300 fighters in training in early January, with supplies provided by the Emirates. At Assosa airport the images showed works begun in August 2025: a hangar, new aprons and a ground control station for drones (Reuters, via TimesLIVE; The EastAfrican). Reuters said it could not independently verify the role of the Emirates or the purpose of the works at the airport; the Emirates denied it (The National). A few days later Ethiopia refused to renew the accreditation of three Reuters journalists (CPJ).

The Tigrayan fighters. Ethiopia's accusation also has a documented basis. During the Tigray war, between 2020 and 2022, thousands of Tigrayan fighters took refuge in Sudan's Gedaref state; some were trained soldiers, former UN peacekeepers (The New Humanitarian). According to Sudanese and Ethiopian sources interviewed by the independent Egyptian outlet Mada Masr, they formed a group called "Army 70", with thousands of men, which fights alongside the Sudanese army against the RSF; in August one of its units reportedly crossed the border into Ethiopia near Humera before being pushed back (Mada Masr). These are anonymous sources, and one of the two is an Ethiopian military officer, that is, a party to the dispute.

The region. On 1 October Ethiopia expelled ten Eritrean diplomats and Eritrea broke off relations (Sudan Tribune). The same day Ethiopia expelled an Egyptian diplomat without giving a reason, and Egypt responded in kind (Ahram Online). Meanwhile Sudan's civil war, which

began in April 2023, has forced more than 14 million people to flee, according to the UN (Reuters, via The National). For the Norwegian Refugee Council, Sudan's is the most neglected displacement crisis in the world (NRC, June 2026). We wrote about the supply network that feeds this war in "Sudan, the war at a distance"; about the war in Ethiopia, in the "Ethiopia" series.

LEGAL COMMENTARY

What the law forbids. The UN Charter forbids every state to use force against another state (Article 2, paragraph 4; see use of force). A state does not need to send its own army to violate it. In 1986, in Nicaragua v. United States, the International Court of Justice ruled that arming and training another country's rebels is an unlawful use of force and a prohibited intervention (ICJ). The Friendly Relations Declaration, adopted by the General Assembly in 1970 and regarded as an authoritative interpretation of the Charter, adds a second prohibition: a state must not even *tolerate* armed activities organised on its territory against a neighbour (resolution 2625). As early as 1949, in the Corfu Channel case, the Court said that no state may knowingly allow its territory to be used against the rights of another (ICJ).

What would need to be proven. If the drones really take off from Assosa, the legal question is what Ethiopia knew and what it did. Letting drones take off from one's own airport, with infrastructure built for the purpose, can hardly be an activity the state knows nothing about. But it is an "if": today it is asserted by a party to the war, with evidence no third party has examined, and made plausible by a press investigation, not an international inquiry.

The rule also applies the other way. If the Sudanese army hosts, pays and arms Tigrayan fighters who cross the border to fight in Ethiopia, it violates exactly the same rules. Using them against the RSF inside Sudan is another matter; letting them leave for Ethiopia is not.

Self-defence. Sudan says it reserves the right to defend itself. The Charter allows this against an "armed attack" (Article 51), but here the attack comes from an armed group, not from the Ethiopian army. In 2005, in the case between the Democratic Republic of the Congo and Uganda, the Court rejected the self-defence claimed by Uganda against rebels operating from Congolese territory, because their attacks were not attributable to Congo (ICJ). Striking Ethiopia on its own territory, without proof of a direct Ethiopian role, would put Sudan in the wrong and open a war between states.

Power stations and civilians. A power station that serves a city is a civilian object, unless it is used for military purposes; even then, an attack must not cause disproportionate harm to civilians. Leaving millions of people in the dark is harm that has to be weighed before striking.

Whoever launches the drones bears first responsibility. Whoever supplies or hosts them knowing how they are used cannot claim to be uninvolved.

Who judges. Almost no one. The UN arms embargo covers only Darfur. On 8 October the Security Council extended it until 11 December, but Russia and China blocked the US proposal to extend it to the whole of Sudan (Al Jazeera, 9/10/2026): drones striking Blue Nile, Kordofan or Omdurman fall outside it. In 2025 Sudan took the Emirates to the International Court of Justice, but the case was struck off because the Emirates, when joining the Genocide Convention, had excluded the Court's jurisdiction (ICJ, 5/5/2025). The African Union's Peace and Security Council sits in Addis Ababa, the capital of the accused country, and Sudan has been suspended from the Union since the 2021 coup (Sudan Tribune).

SYMMETRY TEST

The evidence. We apply the same yardstick to both accusations. Against Ethiopia: the Sudanese government's figures, from a party to the war that has not had them verified, and the Reuters investigation, with satellite imagery and internal documents but also anonymous sources. Against Sudan: the statements of the Ethiopian government, also a party to the war, and reports by The New Humanitarian and Mada Masr on Tigrayan fighters alongside the Sudanese army, with largely anonymous sources. On one point the two accusations are alike: the least proven part is the most serious. No one has shown that Ethiopia authorises the drone launches, nor that Sudan arms the Tigrayans to attack Ethiopia.

The embargo. Sudan asks the UN to stop the weapons reaching the RSF from abroad. But in October its ambassador to the UN opposed extending the embargo to the whole country, arguing that it would violate the right to self-defence (same Al Jazeera source). An embargo for everyone would also have hit the army's weapons.

The drones. Sudan denounces RSF drones over its power stations. But the Sudanese army also uses drones, and its drones also kill civilians, as we documented in "Sudan, the war at a distance". Whoever asks the UN to stop other people's drones is implicitly asking it to look at their own as well.

The press. A government that disputes an investigation answers with evidence, not by withdrawing the accreditation of those who wrote it.

OUR JUDGEMENT

This section expresses the site's position. It is separate from the facts set out above.

Closing a consulate costs little and kills no one. But in this region it is the gesture that usually comes before the ones that cost and kill. Sudan and Ethiopia are each fighting a civil war, and each helps, or is accused of helping, the other's enemies. If the two accusations are true even in part, the road leads to a war between states, right where there is already the largest and most neglected displacement crisis in the world.

Sudan did the right thing: instead of responding on its own, it turned to the UN and the African Union. Now it is up to them. An independent commission to examine the flight data, the wreckage and Assosa airport, and with the same mandate the camps of Tigrayan fighters in eastern Sudan, would cost little. Not setting one up would mean leaving the truth to those who use it as a weapon.

WHAT TO WATCH

- Whether the Security Council or the AU Peace and Security Council discusses Sudan's complaint, and whether Ethiopia responds formally.
- The expiry of the Darfur embargo on 11 December: whether it is renewed, and whether extending it to all of Sudan comes back on the table.
- Whether the UN panel of experts on Sudan, in office until 11 January 2027, examines the flight data and the wreckage.
- New drone attacks in Blue Nile and on the power grid, and where they are launched from.
- The Tigray offensive and the role, if proven, of fighters coming from Sudan.

Sources: AFP, via Ahram Online · Arab News · Middle East Monitor · Euronews Arabic · AFP, via Kuwait Times · AFP, via Kahawatungu · Reuters, via TimesLIVE · Sudan Tribune · Reuters, via Arab News · Addis Media Network, Ethiopian state media · Al-Monitor · Al Jazeera, 28/9/2026 · SUNA, via allAfrica · Fides · Reuters, via TimesLIVE · The EastAfrican · The National · CPJ · The New Humanitarian · Mada Masr · Sudan Tribune · Ahram Online · Reuters, via The National · NRC, June 2026 · ICJ · resolution 2625 · ICJ · ICJ · Al Jazeera, 9/10/2026 · ICJ, 5/5/2025 · Sudan Tribune

5/5 · GLOSSARY · 22 OCTOBER 2026

Ethiopia: its peoples, its history, who is fighting and why

The news from Ethiopia talks about Tigray, the TPLF, Fano, Eritrea and access to the sea, but rarely explains who the peoples involved are, why a country that came out of a war in 2022 is at war again, and who profits from it. This profile gathers the essential background. We keep it updated: every change is logged at the bottom, with its date and source.

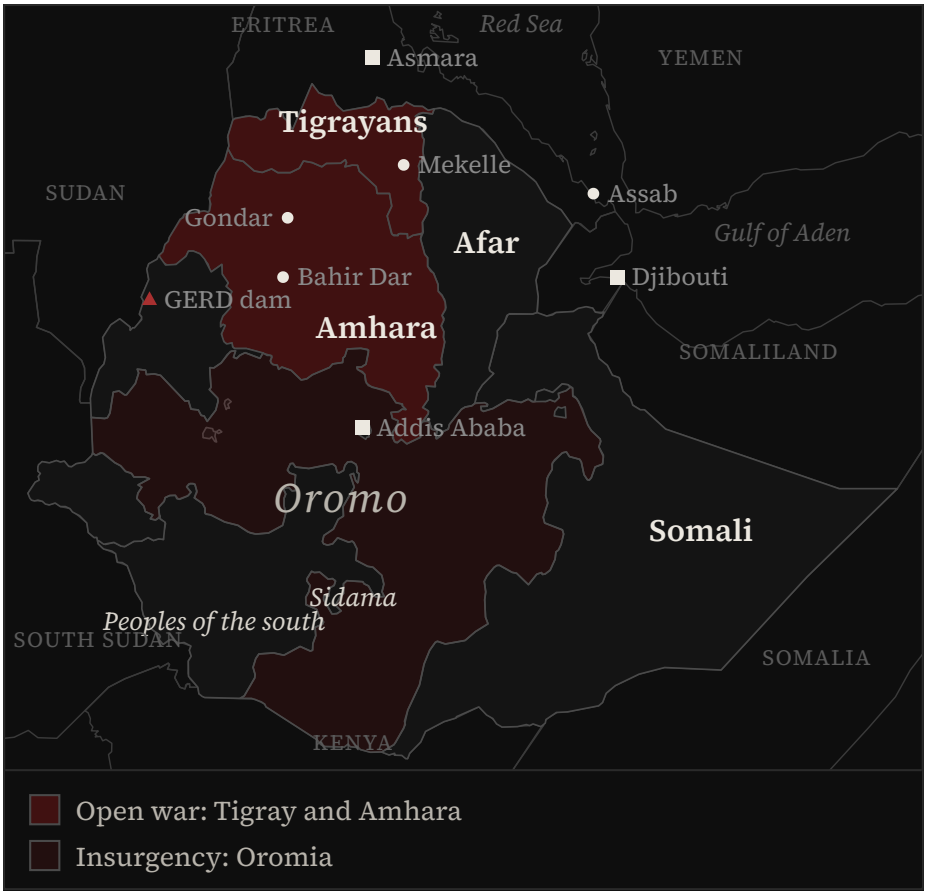
IN BRIEF

- Ethiopia has about 135 million inhabitants and is the second most populous country in Africa. It is a federation of regions drawn largely along ethnic lines: the largest peoples are the Oromo and the Amhara; the Tigrayans, at the centre of the war, are about 6%.
- In 1896 it defeated Italy at Adwa and remained independent. Fascist Italy invaded it in 1935 and occupied it until 1941, using gas and massacring civilians.
- From 1974 to 1991 the military junta known as the Derg ruled; then, for 27 years, a coalition dominated by the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF). In 2018 Abiy Ahmed came to power; he won the Nobel Peace Prize in 2019 and in 2020 took the country to war against Tigray.
- The 2020-2022 war was one of the deadliest of the century: estimates range from fewer than 100,000 to about 600,000 dead. Since 23 September 2026 there has been fighting again: the government against an alliance of Tigrayan, Amhara, Oromo and Afar armed groups. On 4 October the army retook Mekelle.
- Behind the internal war lies a regional confrontation: Ethiopia wants an outlet to the sea and has built the great dam on the Nile; Eritrea, Egypt, Sudan and Somalia have lined up against it. Addis Ababa accuses Eritrea of sending troops into Tigray; Asmara denies it.

LAND AND PEOPLES

Ethiopia is a highland plateau crossed by the Rift Valley and surrounded by arid lowlands to the east and west. The Blue Nile rises on the plateau and carries most of the Nile's water to Egypt. The country has had no outlet to the sea since 1993, when Eritrea became independent and took the whole coastline with it (Britannica). The capital, Addis Ababa, in the centre, is also the seat of the African Union. Tigray is in the far north, on the border with Eritrea; Amhara lies west and

south of Tigray; Oromia, the largest region, surrounds the capital; the lowlands of Afar and the Somali region are in the east.



In dark red, the regions where open war is being fought, Tigray and Amhara; in light red, Oromia, where the OLA insurgency has been active since 2018. Names show where the peoples mentioned in this entry live. We do not draw front lines, which change from week to week. Squares mark capitals; the triangle marks the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam on the Blue Nile. Assab is the Eritrean port Ethiopia lost in 1993. Boundaries: Natural Earth, which still shows the regions as they were before 2020: Sidama and the new southern regions are not drawn.

A warning about the numbers. Official data on the country's peoples still come from the 2007 census, which counted 95 ethnic groups (IRB Canada, via ecoi.net). The percentages below come from that census, as reported by Minority Rights Group (MRG), and should be read as orders of magnitude: the population has since grown to about 135 million (UNFPA), and not every people has grown at the same rate. More recent estimates from other sources give similar shares: Oromo between 34% and 35%, Amhara between 26% and 27%, Tigrayans around 6% (Britannica and the Bertelsmann Stiftung, as reported by IRB Canada, cited above). For some small peoples there is no reliable figure, and we say so.

- **Oromo** — 34.4% (2007 census), the largest people. They live mainly in Oromia, the largest region, with about 40 million inhabitants (AP, via UNB), and speak Oromo. They have long

complained of marginalisation by a government dominated by Tigrayans; from 2015 they protested against plans to expand Addis Ababa onto their farmland (MRG, cited above). Since 2018 the Oromo Liberation Army (OLA) has been fighting in Oromia (AP, cited above).

- **Amhara** — 27% (2007 census). They live on the north-central plateau. Their language, Amharic, is the federal official language. Together with the Tigrayans they historically dominated politics: under Haile Selassie, Amhara language and culture were the model of Ethiopian identity, at the expense of other peoples. Under ethnic federalism they have demanded more autonomy for their region, with protests in Gondar in 2016 (MRG, cited above). Since 2023 the region has been the scene of a war between the army and the Fano militias (our analysis).
- **Somali** — 6.2% (2007 census). Muslim herders of the eastern lowlands, in the Somali region (the Ogaden), which Somalia contested in the war of 1977-1978 (MRG, cited above). The Ogaden National Liberation Front (ONLF) fought there for many years.
- **Tigrayans** — 6.1% (2007 census). They live in Tigray, which has about 7 million inhabitants (our analysis), and speak Tigrinya, like most Eritreans. Most are Orthodox Christians. Although a small minority, through the TPLF they led the federal government from 1991 to 2018, and their presence in the security forces fed the idea of a "Tigrayan" government (MRG, cited above).
- **Sidama** — 4% (2007 census). They live in the south. For decades they demanded a region of their own and obtained it in 2020 after a referendum marked by delays and clashes (Rift Valley Institute, via ecoi.net). After them, other southern peoples demanded and obtained new regions (same source).
- **Afar** — 1.7% (2007 census). They live in the Afar lowlands, in the east, crossed by the road to Djibouti, through which almost all the country's trade passes (our analysis). Under the Derg the government exploited divisions between the Afar and the Somalis (MRG, cited above).
- **Gurage, Wolayta, Hadiya, Gamo, Gedeo and the other peoples of the south** — between 1.3% and 2.5% each (2007 census). They are dozens of peoples speaking different languages.
- **Kunama, Irob and the other small peoples** — together, 8.8% (2007 census). No reliable estimate for the individual groups. In the Gambella region and the Lower Omo, indigenous peoples have been displaced by villagisation programmes, plantations and dams (MRG, cited above).

Religion: about 43.5% are Orthodox Christians and 33.9% Muslims; the rest are Protestants, Catholics or followers of traditional religions (MRG, cited above; 2007 census). Ethiopian

Christianity is among the oldest in the world: in the fourth century King Ezana of Aksum proclaimed it the state religion (National Geographic).

Resources and economy: agriculture, coffee, gold, river water. Between July and December 2025 gold exports reached $2.56 billion, and coffee $1.3 billion in a single quarter (UNDP). Public debt stands at $68.8 billion, which the IMF considers unsustainable; according to the World Bank, poverty rose from 33% in 2016 to 39% in 2021 (same source). In September 2025 Ethiopia inaugurated the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam (GERD) on the Blue Nile: 5,150 megawatts at full capacity, $5 billion, financed almost entirely at home (Khaleej Times). More than 95% of imports and exports pass through Djibouti, at a cost of over $1 billion a year (IBA).

A SHORT HISTORY

The empire. In the first century AD the kingdom of Aksum arose on the northern plateau; in the fourth century, under King Ezana, it became Christian, and between the third and sixth centuries it was one of the powers of the Red Sea (National Geographic, cited above). The Ethiopian empire descends from that Christian core on the plateau, and remained a monarchy until 1974.

Adwa (1896). Italy, which had held the colony of Eritrea since 1890 (Britannica, cited above), tried to extend its rule. On 1 March 1896, at Adwa, Menelik's army defeated it: it was "the first crushing defeat of a European power by African forces during the colonial era" (Britannica). Ethiopia remained independent.

The Italian occupation (1935-1941). In October 1935 Fascist Italy invaded Ethiopia; on 5 May 1936 it took Addis Ababa. Mussolini and Badoglio authorised the use of gas (The Reporter, drawing on Richard Pankhurst). Emperor Haile Selassie appealed to the League of Nations, which did nothing (same source). On 19 February 1937, after an attack on the viceroy Rodolfo Graziani, the Italians laid waste to Addis Ababa for three days: estimates of the dead range from about 3,000 (Del Boca) to about 19,200 (Ian Campbell) to 30,000 (Ethiopian sources) (Domani). On 20 May 1937, on Graziani's orders, the monks of the Debre Libanos monastery were shot: 297 monks and 23 lay people according to Fascist records, up to 1,500-2,000 according to other estimates. In Italy, a bill to create a day of remembrance for the African victims of Italian colonialism has been stuck in parliament for years (Domani, cited above). On 5 May 1941 the British army and Ethiopian partisans liberated the country (The Reporter, cited above).

Haile Selassie (1941-1974). The emperor returned to the throne. In 1952 the former Italian colony of Eritrea was federated with Ethiopia; in 1962 it became an Ethiopian province, and a guerrilla war for independence began that would last thirty years (Britannica, cited above).

The Derg (1974-1991). In 1974 a communist military junta, the Derg, led by Mengistu Haile Mariam, overthrew the emperor (Al Jazeera). From 1976 the "Red Terror" targeted opponents (HRW): up to 30,000 dead according to the most conservative estimates by Africa Watch (University of Pennsylvania). The famine of 1983-1985 killed hundreds of thousands of people, worsened by the war and by government policies (Al Jazeera, cited above); the regime forcibly moved hundreds of thousands of peasants from north to south, and Médecins Sans Frontières, which reported at least 50,000 deaths during the transfers, was expelled (MSF). According to Human Rights Watch, the Derg's actions caused 500,000 or more civilian deaths (HRW, cited above).

The TPLF in power (1991-2018). In 1991 the EPRDF coalition, led by the TPLF, entered Addis Ababa; Mengistu fled to Zimbabwe (HRW, cited above). The Tigrayan leader Meles Zenawi governed until his death in 2012. In 1993 Eritrea became independent (Al Jazeera, cited above). The 1995 Constitution created a federation of ethnically based regions and recognised the peoples' right to self-determination, including secession (Article 39); but power remained highly centralised in the EPRDF, which in 2015, with its allies, won every seat in parliament (MRG, cited above). From 1998 to 2000 Ethiopia and Eritrea fought a border war around the village of Badme, with tens of thousands of dead (Al Jazeera, cited above); the commission set up under the Algiers agreement awarded Badme to Eritrea, but Ethiopia did not accept the decision and the two countries remained for eighteen years in a state of "no war, no peace" (Gulf News).

Abiy Ahmed and the Tigray war (2018-2022). After years of Oromo and Amhara protests, Abiy Ahmed became prime minister in April 2018. Within months he accepted the agreement with Eritrea and travelled to Asmara; in 2019 he received the Nobel Peace Prize (Gulf News, cited above). The TPLF lost federal power and remained in government in Tigray (our analysis). In November 2020 Abiy ordered an offensive against Tigrayan forces, after an attack on a federal military base (Eye Radio). Eritrean troops and Amhara militias fought alongside the army; in Axum, at the end of November 2020, Eritrean soldiers killed hundreds of civilians according to Amnesty International, in a massacre that may amount to a crime against humanity (Amnesty International). A joint investigation by the UN and the Ethiopian Human Rights Commission documented violations by all parties (OHCHR). On 2 November 2022 the Pretoria agreement ended the war (our analysis). The African Union mediator, Olusegun Obasanjo, spoke of around 600,000 dead; the head of the Ethiopian Human Rights Commission urged caution about all estimates (Eye Radio, cited above).

After Pretoria (2023-2026). In 2023 the government tried to dissolve the Amhara regional special forces: the Fano militias, which had fought alongside the army, rebelled (our analysis). On 1 January 2024 Abiy signed a memorandum with Somaliland, Somalia's breakaway region, to

lease about 20 km of coastline for fifty years in exchange for future recognition; Somalia considers it a violation of its sovereignty (IBA, cited above). In 2025 the TPLF lost its registration as a party; in April 2026 it removed the interim administration created by Pretoria and reinstated Debretsion Gebremichael at the top (our analysis). In the June 2026 elections, which were not held in Tigray, the Prosperity Party won 438 seats (Reuters, via Polity).

The new war (since September 2026). On 20 September seven armed groups announced an alliance to overthrow the government. From 23 September the TPLF took the airports of Mekelle, Axum and Shire and attacked towards Amhara and Afar (our analysis). On 1 October Ethiopia closed its embassy in Asmara and Eritrea broke off diplomatic relations (Political.org). On 4 October the federal army re-entered Mekelle without a fight (Al Jazeera); on the 5th Abiy was sworn in for a second term (our analysis). From 7 October the monitoring centre ACLED reported Eritrean troops entering Tigray at Zalambessa; Ethiopia struck them with drones and demanded their withdrawal; Eritrea neither confirmed nor denied it (Political.org, cited above). On 16 October Abiy appointed a caretaker administration for Tigray for six months, with the aim of holding elections (Reuters, via Daily Maverick), entrusted to men close to Getachew Reda and the Tigray Peace Force (Critical Threats). Tigrayan forces have announced a counteroffensive in central Tigray; in Amhara, the Fano are advancing in northern Shewa (same source). No ceasefire has been announced.

WHO GOVERNS, AND HOW

Ethiopia is a federal parliamentary republic: power lies with the prime minister, Abiy Ahmed, in office since 2018, and his Prosperity Party. In the June 2026 elections the party won 438 seats, about 90% of those declared; there was no vote in Tigray, nor in at least eight constituencies in Amhara. The opposition accuses the government of arresting its leaders; the government denies it. In February the authorities did not renew the accreditation of Reuters journalists in Addis Ababa (Daily Monitor, from Reuters).

The Swedish institute **V-Dem**, in its 2026 report, classifies Ethiopia as an "electoral autocracy": people vote, but elections are neither free nor fair (V-Dem). We explain what distinguishes an autocracy from a democracy in the entry Autocracy.

The Constitution is federal and the federalism is ethnic: each region has its own government, its own police and, until 2023, its own special forces. In Tigray, since 16 October 2026, the federal government has installed a caretaker administration, while the TPLF continues to claim authority over the region (Critical Threats, cited above).

WHO'S WHO

Who	Who leads it	Position
Federal government and Prosperity Party, Addis Ababa	Abiy Ahmed, prime minister since 2018	Sees the war as a defence of the unity of the state. Accuses Eritrea, Egypt and Sudan of backing the rebels (Reuters, via Daily Maverick). Calls access to the sea an "existential" issue (IBA)
National Defence Force (ENDF)	Under the prime minister's command	The federal army, with air force and drones. Accused by the UN of raids that hit schools in Tigray and civilians in Amhara (our analysis)
TPLF and Tigray forces (TDF)	Debretsion Gebremichael	Led Ethiopia from 1991 to 2018. Calls the new war "defensive". According to the UN it forcibly recruits civilians, including children (same source)
Tigray Peace Force and the Simret party	Getachew Reda, now an adviser to Abiy	Tigrayans allied with the government, born from a split in the Tigrayan front. They were the first to enter Mekelle and lead the new caretaker administration (Critical Threats)
Fano (Fano National Movement)	Zemene Kassie	Amhara nationalist militias: allies of the army against Tigray in 2020-2022, at war with the government since 2023. They chair the opposition alliance (our analysis). Human Rights Watch attributes war crimes to both sides in Amhara (our analysis)
Oromo Liberation Army (OLA)	Jaal Marroo	Insurgency in Oromia since 2018. UN investigators accuse it of killings, rape and abductions; government forces are accused of indiscriminate drone strikes, extrajudicial killings and enforced disappearances (AP, via UNB)
Eritrea	Isaias Afwerki, president	Ethiopia's ally in the 2020-2022 war, now its enemy. Denies backing the rebels and invading Tigray; accuses Addis Ababa of seeking a pretext to attack Eritrea and the port of Assab (Al Jazeera)

Who	Who leads it	Position
Egypt, Sudan, Somalia	Al-Sisi, al-Burhan, Hassan Sheikh Mohamud	With Eritrea, they signed the El Alamein declaration on 4 October 2026: the Red Sea should remain with the coastal states, and no "unilateral measures" on the Nile. Egypt and Sudan deny backing the rebels (same source)

WHERE THE CONFLICT COMES FROM

We use the four levels of our piece "Are the world's wars 'Muslim'?". Here religion is not the front line: the Tigrayans, Amhara and most of the Oromo who are fighting one another are mostly Christian.

The ground: an empire turned federation. The empire governed from the centre, making Amhara language and culture the model of Ethiopian identity; the Derg recognised regional autonomy only on paper (MRG, cited above). The TPLF turned that model upside down with ethnic federalism: each people its own territory, with the right, on paper, to secede. But the boundaries between regions left contested lands between Tigray and Amhara, which remained under Amhara control even after Pretoria (our analysis); and those who live in "someone else's" region feel like foreigners in their own home.

This does not absolve those who govern today. The TPLF governed for 27 years with a centralised system that won every seat (MRG, cited above). Abiy's government took the war to Tigray with the help of a foreign army, Eritrea's, and then broke with the Amhara militias that had helped it. All armed parties are accused by the UN of crimes against civilians.

The spark: the succession of 2018. The war stems from the TPLF's loss of power. In 2018 the party that had governed for almost three decades was left in control of Tigray alone; in November 2020 the war began. The Pretoria agreement stopped the fighting but did not resolve the core issues: disarmament, the return of the displaced, the contested lands (our analysis).

The flag: unity versus autonomy. The government fights for the unity of the state and calls the war in Amhara a "security problem" (same source). The opposition alliance says it is fighting for the "survival" of the peoples it represents and demands Abiy's fall. Both flags are political; neither makes it lawful to strike a school or recruit a child.

The external multiplier: the sea and the Nile. The internal war has fused with a regional confrontation. Ethiopia wants an outlet to the sea, and its neighbours fear it will seek one by force, at Assab or in Somaliland; Egypt, which depends on the Nile for about 90% of its fresh

water, considers the Ethiopian dam an existential threat (Khaleej Times, cited above). Every enemy of Addis Ababa has an interest in weakening it, and Addis Ababa has an interest in presenting every rebellion as directed from abroad.

WHO PROFITS

We document declared or verifiable interests, not motives. If an actor denies something, we say so.

Abiy's government. Retaking Tigray allows it to install a friendly administration and to settle accounts with the TPLF, whose registration as a party it had already revoked. Abiy was sworn in for his second term promising to work towards an outlet to the sea (our analysis); a war with Eritrea, if it comes, would revolve around that port. The government denies having military designs on Eritrea: in March Abiy said Ethiopia would not go to war over the sea (Africanews).

The TPLF. It is fighting to return to power in Tigray, from which it was excluded by the elections and now by the caretaker administration. In its alliance with Fano and the OLA it has sought allies among peoples who were until recently its adversaries.

Eritrea. It fought against TPLF-led Ethiopia in 1998-2000, remained for eighteen years in a state of "no war, no peace", and in 2020 sent its troops into Tigray alongside Abiy (Gulf News, cited above). Today, according to the Ethiopian government, it finances the rebel alliance; Asmara denies it (Reuters, via Daily Maverick). Its declared interest is to prevent Ethiopia from gaining "sovereign access to the sea" at its expense (Political.org, cited above). On 13 October the Ethiopian army showed foreign diplomats weapons it says it seized from the TPLF, including Iranian-made and Turkish-Pakistani drones, as well as Eritrean uniforms and documents (Critical Threats, cited above).

Egypt and Sudan. For Cairo, a weak Ethiopia is an Ethiopia less able to manage the Nile dam on its own; together with Sudan it has for years demanded a binding agreement on the filling and operation of the dam (Khaleej Times, cited above). Both deny backing the rebels. Ethiopia and Sudan accuse each other of interfering in each other's wars (Al Jazeera).

Those who sell weapons. During the 2020-2022 war the United Arab Emirates organised an air bridge of more than 90 flights to Ethiopia, and satellite images showed Chinese Wing Loong drones at an Ethiopian base; in August 2021 Ethiopia signed a military cooperation agreement with Turkey (Al Jazeera). Since then the government has used drones, above all Turkish Bayraktar TB2s but also Chinese and Iranian models, in Tigray, Amhara and Oromia, with hundreds of civilian victims (The New Humanitarian).

Somalia and Somaliland. The 2024 memorandum with Somaliland pushed Mogadishu towards Cairo and Asmara. Today the Somali president says he does not object to Ethiopia having commercial access to Somali ports, provided it is agreed with Mogadishu (same source).

WHO INTERVENES FROM OUTSIDE

- **The African Union.** It mediated the Pretoria agreement in 2022 (our analysis); its headquarters are in Addis Ababa.
- **The United States, the European Union, the United Kingdom, Canada.** On 13 October 2026 Abiy's adviser Getachew Reda met the EU special envoy for the Horn of Africa; on the 14th US Secretary of State Rubio asked Abiy to respect sovereignty and end cross-border incursions; on the 15th Canada and the United Kingdom called for restraint (Critical Threats).
- **The UN.** Ethiopia has asked the Security Council to respond to the presence of Eritrean troops; Eritrea has asked the same against Ethiopia (Al Jazeera).

The human cost. There is no death toll for the current war. About 750,000 Tigrayans were still displaced in February 2026 from the previous war (UNHCR, cited by Reuters, via Daily Maverick). Across the country there are 1.9 million internally displaced people, and Ethiopia hosts 1.1 million refugees; malnutrition affects 4.4 million children and pregnant or breastfeeding women, and because of funding shortfalls emergency food aid covers 60% of the ration (WFP). In Tigray the regional administration has been unable to pay the salaries of about 137,000 civil servants since March, and the region also faces drought (Al Jazeera).

INTERNATIONAL LAW

The treaties. According to the University of Minnesota database (HRL Minnesota) and the UN (OHCHR), Ethiopia:

- has been a party to the Genocide Convention since 1949;
- has been a party to the Geneva Conventions since 1969 and to the two Additional Protocols since 1994;
- has been a party to the Convention against Torture since 1994 and to the Protocol on children in armed conflict since 2014;
- has **not** signed the Rome Statute: the International Criminal Court can act only on a referral from the Security Council, where such a decision can be blocked by the veto of a permanent member.

Eritrea, Egypt and Sudan are bound by international law just as Ethiopia is; the TPLF, the Fano and the OLA, as armed groups, are bound by humanitarian law just as the army is.

The internal conflict. Common Article 3 of the Geneva Conventions and the Second Protocol apply: they prohibit attacks on civilians and on civilian objects such as schools and hospitals, require that aid be allowed through, and prohibit recruiting children under 15; the Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child raises the limit to 18 for armed groups (our analysis).

Eritrea. If Eritrean troops operate on Ethiopian territory without the consent of the government in Addis Ababa, that is a use of force between states, prohibited by the UN Charter except in self-defence. Likewise, an Ethiopian attack on Eritrea to obtain a port would be an act of aggression. The UN Convention on the Law of the Sea recognises a right of access to the sea for landlocked states, but the terms of transit must be agreed with the transit states (IBA, cited above): the sea is negotiated, not conquered.

Justice denied. No one has been tried internationally for the crimes of the 2020-2022 war. The Pretoria agreement, as we have written, is not a treaty with a judge but a political commitment (same source). For the Italian occupation, in 1946 Ethiopia raised the question of war crimes at the Paris Peace Conference without receiving an answer (Domani, cited above).

TIMELINE

Year	Event
4th cent.	King Ezana makes Christianity the state religion of Aksum
1890	Eritrea becomes an Italian colony
1896	Menelik II defeats Italy at Adwa (1 March)
1935-1936	Fascist Italy invades Ethiopia and uses gas; capture of Addis Ababa (5 May 1936)
1937	Massacres of Addis Ababa (19-21 February) and Debre Libanos (20 May)
1941	Liberation (5 May)
1952	Eritrea is federated with Ethiopia; in 1962 it becomes a province
1974	The Derg overthrows Haile Selassie
1976	The Red Terror begins
1983-1985	Famine and forced relocations
1991	The TPLF-led EPRDF takes Addis Ababa
1993	Eritrean independence
1995	Federal constitution on an ethnic basis
1998-2000	War with Eritrea
2018	Abiy Ahmed becomes prime minister; peace with Eritrea
2019	Nobel Peace Prize for Abiy
2020-2022	Tigray war; Pretoria agreement (2 November 2022)
2023	The war in Amhara with the Fano begins
2024	Memorandum with Somaliland (1 January)
2025	Inauguration of the GERD dam (9 September)

Year	Event
2026	The TPLF overthrows the Pretoria administration (April); elections without Tigray (June); alliance of seven armed groups (20 September); war from 23 September; break with Eritrea (1 October); the army retakes Mekelle (4 October); caretaker administration for Tigray (16 October)

CHANGE LOG

- 22 October 2026: first version.

Sources: Britannica · IRB Canada, via ecoi.net · MRG · UNFPA · AP, via UNB · Rift Valley Institute, via ecoi.net · National Geographic · UNDP · Khaleej Times · IBA · Britannica · The Reporter, drawing on Richard Pankhurst · Domani · Al Jazeera · HRW · University of Pennsylvania · MSF · Gulf News · Eye Radio · Amnesty International · OHCHR · Reuters, via Polity · Political.org · Al Jazeera · Reuters, via Daily Maverick · Critical Threats · Daily Monitor, from Reuters · V-Dem · Africanews · Al Jazeera · The New Humanitarian · Al Jazeera · WFP · HRL Minnesota · OHCHR

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